THE FOUNDERY CHURCH · SUNDAY NOVEMBER 1, 2026

GIVE ME EARS TO HEAR ....
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A Study Guide on Hearing the Heart of Jesus (Part 1 of 3: Ears to Hear, Eyes to See, Feet to Go and Hands to Serve)

SERMON CONTENT
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1. THE BIG IDEA: HOW WE HEAR SHAPES HOW WE LIVE

This message opens a three-part series on asking God for ears to hear, eyes to see, and feet to go and hands to serve. We begin with hearing because we cannot see the world as Jesus does or serve with His love until we understand the heart of the One we follow. The central question is this: have we become so familiar with the words of Jesus that we are missing the heart of Jesus? Our big idea is that how we hear the gospel shapes how we live it and share it with others. Sometimes it takes stepping outside the familiar to notice what we have stopped seeing in our own lives.

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2. WHEN FOLLOWING JESUS BECOMES RELIGIOUS MAINTENANCE

We live surrounded by Jesus: His name on T-shirts and billboards, Bibles on our phones, sermons and podcasts on demand. Yet familiarity can leave us hearing about Him more than listening to Him. Jesus' call to follow can shrink into a checklist: read, pray, attend, give, avoid the 'don'ts.' If we check enough boxes we feel secure, and if we don't we feel we have failed Him. Jesus never handed out a better list of rules. He called fishermen, ate with sinners, and confronted religious leaders who knew the Scriptures but missed the God those Scriptures reveal. His commands are real, but they were never meant to substitute for knowing Him.

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3. ESCAPING THE MISERABLE MIDDLE

Pastor Jonny Ardavanis calls it the 'miserable middle': we have learned what Christians should not do, but we have not learned to delight in the God who saved us. We no longer chase the pleasures of sin, yet we are not experiencing the fullness of knowing God either. Jesus did not come so that we could spend our lives miserable and trying not to do bad things. He came to give life to the full, life that begins when we know Him. This does not mean life is free of suffering or temptation. It means there is a joy that does not depend on circumstances, because David locates joy in God's presence, not in accomplishments or flawless performance.

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4. ENJOYING THE EXPERIENCE OR ENJOYING THE PRESENCE?

In Liberia, the church worshiped without modern lighting, sound, glass windows, air conditioning, or screens. What stood out was how much they enjoyed the One they had gathered to worship: they sang, prayed, and danced with real joy. We can be grateful for our facilities and still ask whether we have confused enjoying the experience of church with enjoying the presence of God. It is possible to enjoy the music without worshiping and to appreciate a sermon without surrendering to it. The better question after a service may be whether our hearts were turned toward Him, not whether church was everything we wanted.

5. WHOEVER HAS EARS, LET THEM HEAR

Jesus said 'Whoever has ears, let them hear' to people who could plainly hear Him, because hearing and receiving are not the same. We can hear a call to repentance and receive only condemnation, when He is calling us out of what destroys us and into joy. We can hear 'love your enemies' and list reasons people don't deserve it, or hear 'forgive' and focus on our hurt rather than the mercy we have received. In the parable of the sower, the same seed falls on every soil, and the difference is how it is received. When we hear a sermon, we often think of someone else who needs it. We need to ask, 'Jesus, what are You wanting me to hear? What are You revealing about Yourself?'

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6. FOCUS PASSAGE: JOHN 8:1-11

At dawn Jesus is teaching in the temple courts when the teachers of the law and the Pharisees bring a woman caught in adultery. They are not seeking forgiveness or answers. They are using her to trap Jesus. He bends down and writes on the ground, then says, 'Let any one of you who is without sin be the first to throw a stone at her.' One by one her accusers leave, until only Jesus and the woman remain. He tells her, 'Then neither do I condemn you. Go now and leave your life of sin.' Read the passage slowly this week, and let it be both a story about her and a mirror for you. The sermon draws three things to hear from it, covered in the next three sections.

7. HEAR THE STORY OF GOD'S LOVE

The woman has become a means to an end: her humiliation is useful to the leaders. The Law held both the man and the woman accountable, yet only she is brought forward, and we should not invent details Scripture does not give. We do something similar when we reduce people to what we know about their sin and assume our opinion of them is God's. Knowing about someone's sin is not the same as knowing God's heart toward that person. In Matthew 9, Jesus tells Scripture scholars to 'go and learn' what mercy means, quoting Hosea 6:6, where the Hebrew word hesed speaks of steadfast,

covenant love that does not vanish when we fail. Jesus came for the sick, not the already righteous, and He came because He loved us, not because we had made ourselves worthy. We can be just as harsh with ourselves, believing our failures put us beyond His mercy.

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8. HEAR HOW GOD'S LOVE DEALS WITH OUR SIN

Jesus does not say the woman is innocent or that adultery is acceptable. He confronts the accusers, turning the conversation from her sin to theirs. Jesus takes sin more seriously than we do and understands mercy more deeply than we do, and He never compromises holiness for love or love for holiness. Romans 2:1 warns that when we judge others, we condemn ourselves (the Greek word is katakrinō, which returns later in the story). The checklist mindset tempts us to compare ourselves with people whose failures are more visible and to feel less dependent on grace. But the publicly fallen, the privately struggling, and the fifty-year believer all live by grace, and no one graduates beyond it. The accusers 'heard' and walked away, but the text never says they repented. Conviction is not the destination, because it is meant to lead us to surrender.

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9. HEAR GOD'S LOVE CALL US INTO NEW LIFE

When Jesus says 'Neither do I condemn you,' He uses katakrinō, the same word as in Romans 2. The only One with the right to condemn her declines to. Some of us love the mercy and skip the call to change, while others cling to the command and barely notice the mercy before it, and both miss His heart. The order matters: mercy first, then 'Go now and leave your life of sin.' Repentance (metanoia, a change of mind and a turning) is not only about

what we give up. It is about the life Jesus invites us into, and obedience becomes the joyful response of someone who has received mercy. In Ezekiel 36:26-27, God promises a new heart and His Spirit within us, so He does not just command a different life but transforms the heart it is lived from. A checklist cannot make us love Jesus, fear cannot produce joy, and guilt cannot give us a new heart.

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10. DIFFERENT DOESN'T MEAN DEFICIENT: LESSONS FROM LIBERIA

We tend to measure other people's worlds by what we are used to, and we can move from 'different' to 'better' without noticing. The same happens when we confuse our cultural expressions of Christianity with Christianity itself. The gospel is no more true because of where it is preached or the language it is spoken in. The Jesus worshiped in Liberia is the same Jesus we worship here, the same One who hears their prayers, loves them, and died for them. The Liberian church does not need to become the American church to be the church of Jesus Christ. Our comforts do not make us more faithful, and they may sometimes keep us from Him. All of us simply need to hear His voice, receive His Word, and follow where He leads.

11. WHERE ARE YOU STANDING IN THIS STORY?

The sermon invites us to locate ourselves honestly in John 8. If you are in the miserable middle with a spiritual spreadsheet, Jesus is not standing over you with a clipboard but is calling you into life. If you have been holding the stones, quick to see what is wrong with others, let the stone drop, don't walk away from the conviction, and walk toward the One who has mercy. If you are the one standing exposed, hear Jesus say, 'Neither do I condemn you,' and let Him lead you into life to the full. Spend a few quiet minutes identifying where you are today and what you need to hear from Him.

12. PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE THIS WEEK

Pray the prayer of the series: 'God, give me ears to hear the story of Your love. Not just the parts that make me comfortable, not just the parts that affirm what I already believe, not just the parts that tell me what I need to do. Give me ears to hear Your heart.' When you open your Bible, ask 'Jesus, what are You wanting me to hear? What are You revealing about Yourself?' before asking 'What am I supposed to do?' Choose one familiar passage and read it as if for the first time. Then tell the story of a Savior who comes with mercy first and calls us into new life, to your family, your neighbors, and anyone you have been tempted to see only through their sin.

SCRIPTURE REFERENCES

John 5:39-40
"You study the Scriptures diligently because you think that in them you have eternal life. These are the very Scriptures that testify about me, yet you refuse to come to me to have life."
(NIV)

John 10:10
"The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full."
(NIV)

Psalm 16:11
"You make known to me the path of life; you will fill me with joy in your presence, with eternal pleasures at your right hand."
(NIV)

Matthew 11:15
"Whoever has ears, let them hear."
(NIV)

Matthew 13:9, 13

"Whoever has ears, let them hear. ... Though seeing, they do not see; though hearing, they do not hear or understand."
(NIV)

John 8:1-11
"But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives. At dawn he appeared again in the temple courts, where all the people gathered around him, and he sat down to teach them. The teachers of the law and the Pharisees brought in a woman caught in adultery. They made her stand before the group and said to Jesus, 'Teacher, this woman was caught in the act of adultery. In the Law Moses commanded us to stone such women. Now what do you say?' They were using this question as a trap, in order to have a basis for accusing him. But Jesus bent down and started to write on the ground with his finger. When they kept on questioning him, he straightened up and said to them, 'Let any one of you who is without sin be the first to throw a stone at her.' Again he stooped down and wrote on the ground. At this, those who heard began to go away one at a time, the older ones first, until only Jesus was left, with the woman still standing there. Jesus straightened up and asked her, 'Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?' 'No one, sir,' she said. 'Then neither do I condemn you,' Jesus declared. 'Go now and leave your life of sin.'"
(NIV)

Matthew 9:12-13
"It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick. But go and learn what this means: 'I desire mercy, not sacrifice.' For I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners."
(NIV)

Romans 2:1
"You, therefore, have no excuse, you who pass judgment on someone else, for at whatever point you judge another, you are condemning yourself, because you who pass judgment do the same things."
(NIV)

Ezekiel 36:26-27
"I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you; I will remove from you your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees and be careful to keep my laws."

(NIV)

Hosea 6:6
"For I desire mercy, not sacrifice, and acknowledgment of God rather than burnt offerings."
(NIV)

Romans 8:1
"Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
(NIV)

James 1:22
"Do not merely listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves. Do what it says."
(NIV)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

For personal reflection or group discussion

1. The sermon asks, 'Have we become so familiar with the words of Jesus that we are missing the heart of Jesus?' What are some ways familiarity has dulled your hearing of Scripture?

Your thoughts:
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2. Where do you see the 'checklist' mindset in your own spiritual life? How does it affect how you feel about God's love for you when you have a good week or a bad one?

Your thoughts:
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3. Read John 5:39-40. How can a person study Scripture diligently and still refuse to come to Jesus for life? What would coming to Jesus look like in practice?

Your thoughts:
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4. The 'miserable middle' describes avoiding sin without delighting in God. Does that description resonate with you? What helps you move from resisting sin toward enjoying God's presence?

Your thoughts:
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5. After a worship service, do you tend to evaluate the experience or examine your heart? What would it look like to measure Sunday differently?

Your thoughts:
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6. Jesus said, 'Whoever has ears, let them hear,' to people who could hear Him. What is the difference between hearing and receiving? Describe a time you heard a truth but did not let it change you.

Your thoughts:
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7. In John 8:1-11, notice how the religious leaders used the woman as a means to an end. In what ways are we tempted to reduce people to what we know about their sin?

Your thoughts:
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8. Jesus does not excuse the woman's sin, and He does not condemn her. Why do we find it hard to hold holiness and mercy together? Which do you lean toward, and why?

Your thoughts:
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9. Read John 8:9 again. The accusers heard and left, but nothing says they repented. How can we tell the difference between being confronted by truth and surrendering to it?

Your thoughts:
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10. Which statement do you find easier to hear, 'Neither do I condemn you' or 'Go now and leave your life of sin'? What does the order of the two statements teach us about repentance?

Your thoughts:
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11. How does seeing repentance as an invitation into a new life, and not only a list of things to give up, change the way you think about obedience?

Your thoughts:
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12. The sermon says our blessings can sometimes keep us from Jesus, and that different does not mean deficient. Where might you be confusing a cultural expression of Christianity with the gospel itself?

Your thoughts:
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13. Of the three people described at the end (the one in the miserable middle, the one holding stones, the one standing exposed), which are you today? What do you most need to hear from Jesus?

Your thoughts:
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14. Who in your life have you been tempted to identify only by their sin? What would it look like to tell them the story of a Savior who comes with mercy first?

Your thoughts:
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KEY TAKEAWAYS

Main points to remember and apply

1. How we hear the gospel shapes how we live it and share it with others.
2. We can become so familiar with the words of Jesus that we miss His heart.
3. Jesus did not come to give us a better checklist but to invite us into a life we could never produce on our own.
4. Fullness of joy is found in God's presence, not in religious performance or in enjoying the church experience.
5. Knowing about someone's sin is not the same as knowing God's heart toward them.
6. Jesus is perfectly holy and perfectly loving, and He never compromises one for the other.
7. Conviction is not the destination, and it is meant to lead us to surrender.
8. Mercy comes first: 'Neither do I condemn you' precedes 'Go now and leave your life of sin.'
9. Repentance is an invitation into new life, and God gives a new heart that checklists, fear, and guilt cannot produce.
10. This week, ask 'Jesus, what are You wanting me to hear?' and then tell others the story of His mercy.

ADDITIONAL NOTES

• Personal reflection: Where am I standing in John 8 today (the accuser, the one exposed, or the one trying to keep the checklist)? Write your honest answer here: _____
• What is one familiar passage I will read this week asking, 'Jesus, what are You revealing about Yourself?' _____
• Who is one person I have reduced to their sin or their reputation, and how can I show them mercy this week? _____
• Notes from the sermon: _____
• My prayer: 'God, give me ears to hear the story of Your love.' Write what you sense God saying: _____

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